making a rubber stamp, had been taken care of as well. Mr Rajaram had been in Goa for less than a week.

These were the humble beginnings of the Konkan Railways.

The then Railway Minister George Fernandes had announced in Parliament that the whole project would be completed in five years' time, and Rajaram and his team did not waste a day on the ground. With such a tight deadline, engineers had to think fast, and creatively. 'Conventionally,' says Mr Rajaram, 'when an alignment needs to be worked out, you require several Jeeps, and lots of people running around.' Mr Rajaram thought there were better ways. What he did was take satellite images, make topographical maps with high accuracy, and send out teams on motorcycles.

He ordered several Kawasaki bikes, modified to carry equipment like levelling instruments, and hired young boys, fresh with engineering diplomas, to go around the state. They were given ₹100 per day, and petrol, neither of which they had to account for. 'They had the freedom to go off to the beach and have a good time, so long as they produced a certain amount of work every day,' says Mr Rajaram. 'Of course,' he adds, with a slight smile, 'the targets they were set meant they would have to work fourteen hours a day. But they felt empowered, and so they gave their best. It helped that despite their inexperience, they were given the designation of "engineer", a title they could flaunt with pride.'

Thirty such teams in Goa worked on sixteen alignments, and the data was analysed, often way past midnight, on an assembled computer that Mr Rajaram had bought cheap in Bangalore (now Bengaluru). Mr Rajaram, who is a technical wizard, designed the software for this analysis himself. [14 4]

'MILKMAN' RAIL MINISTER AND A FARE CUT

Soon after the railways had earned a cash surplus of ₹15,000 crore (US$ 3.5 billion) in 2006, Railway Minister Lalu Prasad Yadav was keen for this financial gain to translate into rewards for railway employees, and tangible benefits for the poor travellers who relied on the railways for transportation.

Of his propositions, the most striking was his insistence on reducing second class passenger fares by a rupee per passenger. The Railway Board members were perplexed. Why reduce just one rupee? In most transactions